Acceptable Use of Technology Policy - Summary

Purpose and Scope

This policy ensures that the organization's computers, software, communication tools, network and cloud services, provided to improve productivity, are used responsibly, ethically and lawfully. It applies to all full-time, part-time and temporary employees, contractors, students and interns, and to every system, device and service the organization owns or manages. The policy cannot anticipate every situation, so users remain obliged to exercise good judgment at all times.

General and Personal Use

All devices and systems are the property of the organization. Limited personal use, such as personal correspondence or online banking, is allowed, but it must not reduce productivity, create extra cost, disrupt the network, compromise the organization or conflict with any other policy.

Systems must never be used for illegal or unlawful purposes, including copyright infringement, fraud, defamation, harassment, impersonation, illegal gambling or spreading malicious software.

Users must not buy or adopt technology, applications or services that the IT department has not formally approved. Working around the IT department this way is known as shadow IT and is prohibited.

Issued equipment such as laptops and mobile devices may be used only by the person it was issued to, and that person is accountable for everything done with it. All corporate equipment must be kept physically and logically secured.

Removable Media

Information may be stored on removable media such as USB drives only when a role truly requires it. Phones and tablets must not be used as storage for business or customer data. Any unknown removable media found unattended must be handed to the IT department and never plugged into an organization device. Media must be secured when not in use, never used on non-company systems, wiped once its task is complete and returned to the service desk for safe disposal when no longer needed.

Email, Internet and Remote Access

The email and messaging systems belong to the organization and are monitored. Staff must check email regularly, must not use it for unlawful or offensive content, must not send mass unsolicited messages and must not strain storage or bandwidth, for example by emailing large attachments instead of sharing a link.

Users must not sign in with accounts that are not theirs, must not impersonate others and must not speak on the organization's behalf unless authorized. Attachments and links from unknown sources must not be opened. Offensive or suspicious messages must be reported to the service desk without forwarding, replying or deleting.

Sensitive information must be encrypted before it is sent. Automatic forwarding of company email to external addresses is prohibited. Backup copies of email exist even after a user deletes a message, and email access ends when employment ends.

Remote access to the corporate network is allowed only through the approved virtual private network service, and users must sign in with multi-factor authentication.

Social Media

The organization's social media accounts are for approved business purposes only, such as brand building and customer support, and access requires manager approval. Personal accounts must not be used for company business, and company accounts must not be used for personal matters.

Data Security

All organizational data belongs to the organization, and every user is responsible for protecting it. Data must not be viewed, copied, altered or destroyed without permission. Data is classified by sensitivity, and each classification level has handling rules. Users may access only the data their duties require, may use it for business purposes only and must follow the approved procedures for erasing data that is no longer needed and for retaining records.

Mobile Devices

Anyone using a mobile device to reach corporate resources must apply the same security care as on any other system. Devices must be protected by strong access controls such as a strong password or biometric lock, kept physically secure and never used to store sensitive data or passwords. Computers used to synchronize or back up a mobile device need up-to-date protection against malicious software. The IT department may refuse any device's connection, inspects personal devices before they connect and blocks those that do not meet policy. A lost or stolen device with access to company resources must be reported to the service desk immediately.

Clean Desk and Printing

Workstations must lock when a desk is unoccupied, and laptops must be cable-locked or locked away overnight. Sensitive papers must be cleared from desks, kept in locked cabinets and shredded on disposal. Printouts with sensitive content must be collected from the printer immediately, whiteboards must be wiped after use, access badges must not be left unattended and passwords must never be written down.

Passwords

Access to systems runs through individual accounts and passwords. Accounts and passwords must never be shared, and corporate passwords must not be reused on outside services. If a user suspects someone else has learned their password, they must contact the service desk for a reset. The IT department enforces password strength rules centrally on all systems.

Incidents, Training and Prohibited Security Behaviour

Users must report any suspected security incident to the service desk and must cooperate with the response process, including handing over equipment for investigation when asked. Everyone completes security awareness training when joining, signs a declaration confirming they understand the rules and completes refresher training as scheduled.

The following are always prohibited: introducing malicious programs, contributing to security breaches or disrupting communication, port or security scanning without prior approval, intercepting network traffic not meant for you, bypassing authentication or security controls, attaching unapproved servers or listening devices to the network and denying service to other users.

Noncompliance

Violations are handled like any other allegation of wrongdoing and may lead to disciplinary action, termination of employment or legal action under applicable laws and contracts.